Chrome Web Store, now open

The Google Chrome Web Store is now open for business. In this web store you can browse, discover and purchase web applications in a way similar to the Apple AppStore or the Android Marketplace. Applications in the market could be anything from glorified bookmarks to offline applications.

The decentralised nature of the internet could work well with information, and data sharing. The web needs a directory of applications. The good news for RIA developers, however, is that the Google Chrome Web store might just be it. Web Apps developed for the Google Chrome Store have a similar mechanism for development and delivery as Google Chrome extensions, and are delivered in the same zipped CRX package with an application manifest, and data. The experience of browsing for and installing a web application is also similar to installing a Chrome extension. You simply browse through the Google Chrome Web Store, find an application you like and click on "Install". If the application is a paid product, then there is an intermediary step in which you pay for the app / service.

Here lies another advantage of the Google Chrome Web Store. You can sell web applications similar to desktop applications. You can sell to users Flash or HTML applications that install on the users computer instead of running through a site. With paid applications tied to a particular browser, users will quickly become limited to Google Chrome after they have made a few purchases, and will not be able to take advantage of latest developments in other browsers.

In the meanwhile, Mozilla has its own plans for a completely open web store ecosystem that, unlike Google's Chrome Web Store, is not tied to any browser. Mozilla's concept goes beyond any single store or single provider, but aims instead to be, like the internet – decentralised.

Mozilla continues to refine its plans as Google's store goes online. The Chrome Web Store is an interesting concept that takes web applications forward. We look forward to further developments in Mozilla's Open Web Store concept.

DARPA developing optical fibre alternative

So far, optical fibres are the pinnacle of data transfer performance across large distances, but DARPA wants to move a step further and has commissioned Raytheon BBN Technologies to develop a new photon-based optical network.

The new system promises to be able to deliver very large amounts of data much faster than today's optical networks, and in fact, can even send between Earth and space.

Scientists at Raytheon BBN Technologies are hoping to be able to use free-space optical (FSO) communication to its maximum potential. These are types of lasers that can transmit and receive data between two points, without them being connected physically by fibre optic cables.

Google Chrome to abandon H.264

Google has taken a huge step forward for an open HTML5, by deciding to abandon support for the H.264 video format in their Google Chrome browser in the future.

HTML5 and related technologies are supposed to be a big step for an open web, as they put a number of features at the disposal of web developers that were previously only available through plugins such as Google Gears and Adobe Flash.

Due to the lack of a suitable open codec earlier, the HTML5 specification left out any mention of a recommended codec. Consequently, different web browsers offered support for different codecs. Firefox and Opera stuck to the open formats by offering support for only Ogg Theora video, while Google offered support for both Theora and H.264. Safari on the other hand supported only H.264 video. This meant, that for a web site to reach users on all browsers, the video needed to be available in both Theora and H.264, since no single format worked on all browsers.

Since then, Google has released the WebM / VP8 video codec as an open source format and standard for free use. They also started encoding a majority of their YouTube web videos in the new format. Opera, and Google Chrome now both support the WebM format, and Mozilla will support it in Firefox 4. Microsoft will only support H.264 in their upcoming Internet Explorer 9 browser. Adobe, too, declared that they will include support for VP8 playback in their Flash Player in a future version.

While VP8 might still lags behind H.264 in quality, it is a suitable replacement for the purpose of the web, and is a much better codec than Theora. Once Firefox 4 releases with VP8 support, VP8 will be the most widely supported web video format for HTML5.

By removing support for H.264 video from Google Chrome, Google is not only saying that VP8 is way to go for web video in the future, but also that H.264 is not the way to go.